

July 6, 2026

Biobank Working Group



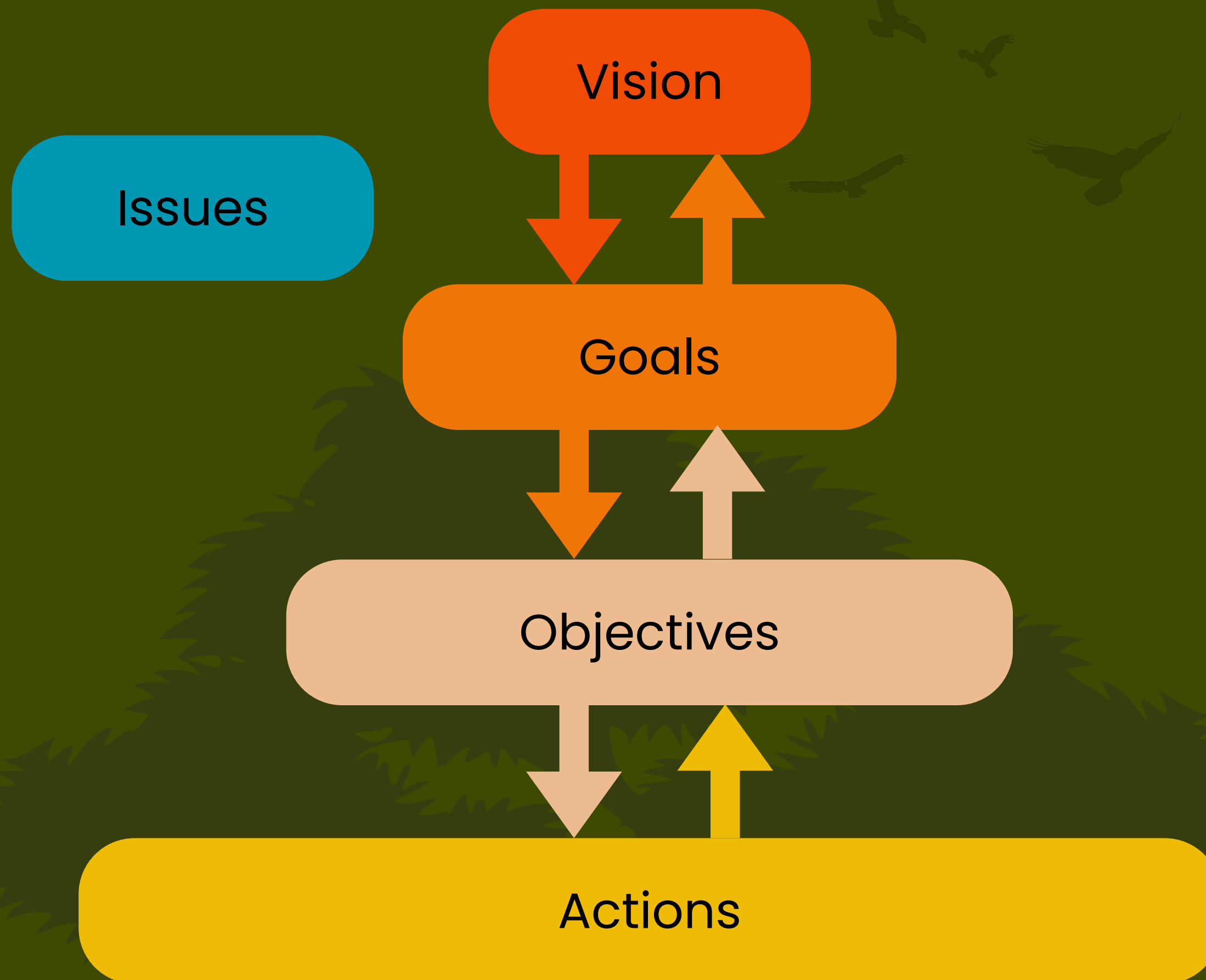
Agenda

- 12:00–12:05 Updates
 - Letter of intent to AZA signed and submitted with RTC Board Report!
 - IMLS grant application
- 12:05–1:20 Goals refinement
- 1:20–1:30 Objectives and wrap-up



Goal for today: Generate a non-overlapping set of well-defined goals that collectively address the issues the group finds most important.





Issues (June meeting)

Sampling stage	Issue	Severity	Leverage	Feasibility	Sum
Post	Limited discoverability of available samples, associated data, and institutional points of contact	28	29	22	79
During	Lack of standardized practices, training, and knowledge transfer for biobank management	23	25	27	75
Pre	Unclear governance and responsibility for coordinated biobanking	26	25	20	71
Pre	Concerns about ownership, control, and future use of samples and data	26	26	19	71
Post	Lack of standardized metadata across institutions and biobanking systems	26	22	21	69
Pre	Lack of shared priorities, capabilities, and alignment across institutions for sample use	25	25	19	69
During	Lack of guidance and support for institutional biobanking infrastructure planning	21	21	24	66
Post	Redundant institutional approval processes for sample and data access	23	23	19	65
During	Limited biobank storage capacity	23	25	17	65
During	Limited dedicated institutional capacity for coordinated biobanking	24	26	14	64
Pre	Limited tracking and recognition of sample/data use and downstream outcomes	18	18	21	57

Goals

Goals: the **conditions** (what) you ultimately want to achieve (not how!)

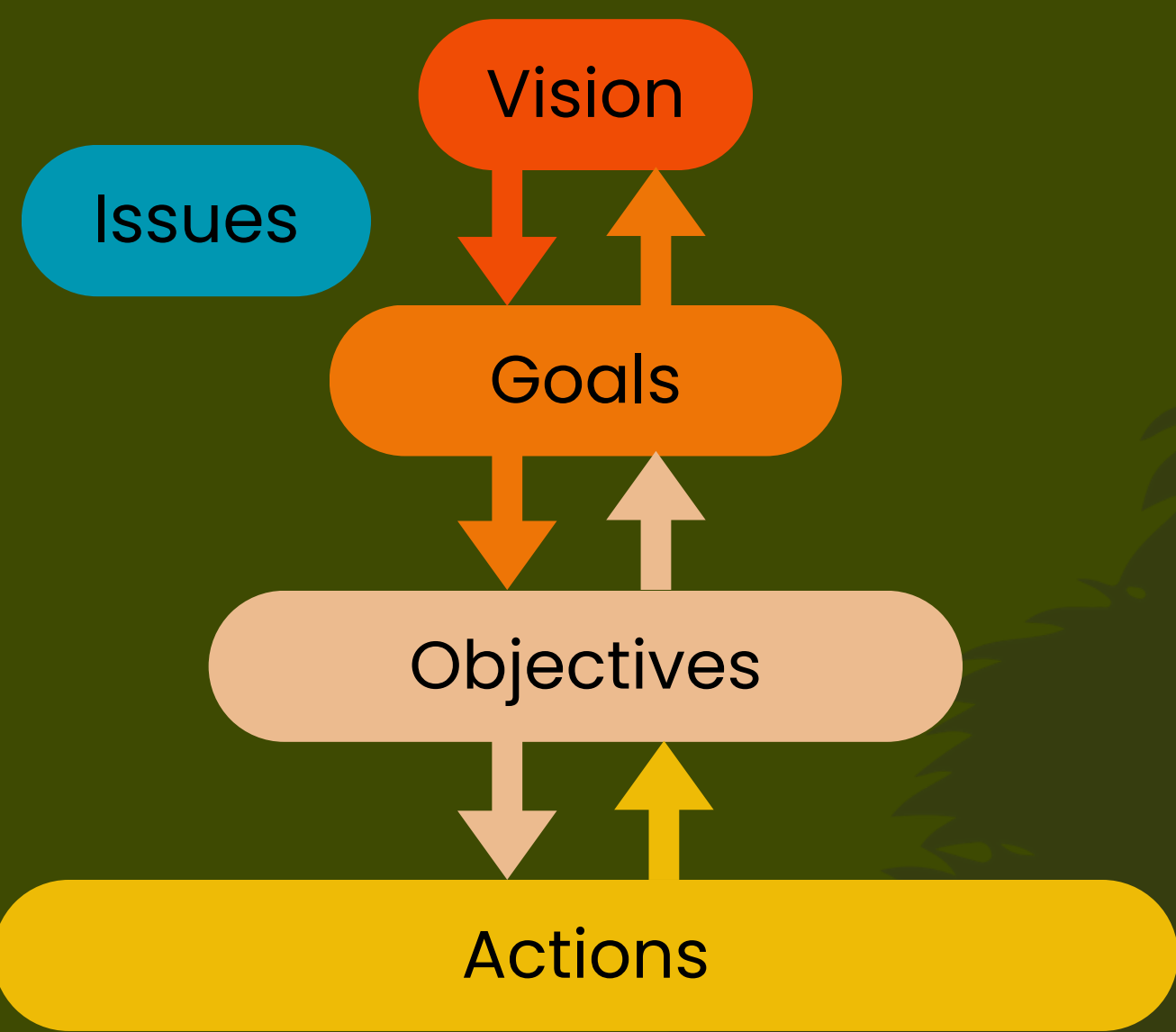
- Includes the desired **condition** & the **reason** why the change would help
- Goals are future conditions, not solutions
- Goals are not databases, policies, forms, committees, software
- Goals should instead sound like:
 - "Institutions can..."
 - "Samples and data are..."
 - "Participation is..."
 - "Users can access..."



Goals

Goals should be general enough that there are **alternative ways** to get there





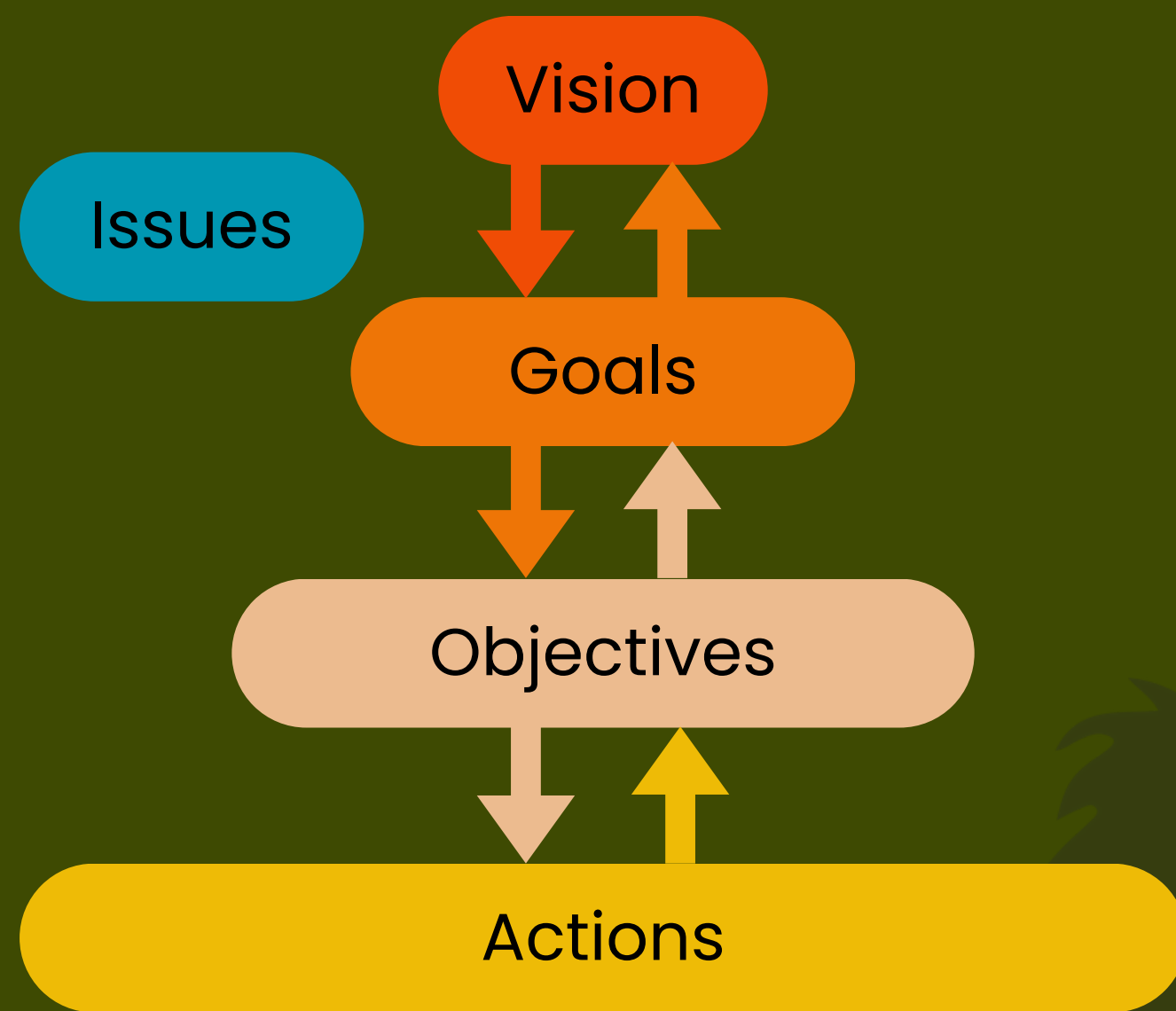
Goal refinement - July 6 Meeting

Goal 1: By 20XX, biological samples and associated data from across zoological and aquarium institutions are seamlessly discoverable, interoperable, and accessible for global research and conservation.

- To accelerate discovery and strengthen population management, biospecimens and associated data across participating AZA institutions are as discoverable, interoperable, and accessible as if they originated from a single institution. -Rachel Johnston (example)
- The broader research community can seamlessly access biological samples and data across zoological institutions - Jennifer D'Agostino
 - For seamless access for research and conservation purposes, zoological institutions will have standardized collection data integrated into online accessible global biodiversity data networks. Debbie Johnson
 - To promote data sharing and accessibility, participating AZA institutions disclose information associated with their biobanked biomaterials to the broader conservation community. - Cynthia Steiner

Goal 2: By 20XX, zoological and aquarium institutions systematically, sustainably, and strategically steward biological samples and associated data through standardized biobanking to maximize value for global research and conservation.

- Zoological institutions are prioritizing banking of biological samples and data in a systematic way to facilitate future research efforts - Jennifer D'Agostino
- Understanding their tremendous value to the research community and potential mission-aligned impact, zoological and aquarium institutions invest in infrastructure, staff, and processes to manage organized, accessible, and standardized reserves of animal biomaterials - John Griffioen
 - To support collaborative biobanking efforts and the standardization of best practices, participating AZA institutions have access to curated biobanking protocols, technical expertise, and training opportunities. - Cynthia Steiner



By 2055, biological specimens and associated data from biodiversity institutions are mobilized seamlessly at scale—driving discovery, strengthening resilient populations, and safeguarding species through fully integrated *ex situ* and *in situ* conservation and research.

To accelerate discovery and strengthen population management, biospecimens and associated data across participating AZA institutions are as discoverable, interoperable, and accessible as if they originated from a single institution.

Objective (2 yr): By 2029, 10 institutions have a designated biobank contact and ≥ 50 samples publicly discoverable.

Objective (5 yr): By 2032, participating institutions adopt a shared minimum metadata standard that enables biospecimens & associated data to be searched and interpreted consistently across institutions.

Objective (10 yr): By 2036, clear, standardized processes for sharing samples across network institutions are implemented, reducing administrative barriers while maintaining trust and appropriate oversight.

Wrap-up

- **Homework**
 - Draft objectives by Friday July 24
- Next meeting: Monday August 3

